With the United States and Russia abandoning the treaty, we are entering a new stage of nuclear rearmament in which old missiles and nuclear bombs are being replaced with new, more precise, and smaller ones. This suggests that tactical nuclear weapons may be used on the battlefield, plunging the world back into the 1960s, when such use was a key part of military doctrine on both sides of the Cold War divide. For all the dramatic changes that have occurred in the world since the fall of the Berlin Wall, the end of the Cold War, and the disintegration of the USSR, we still have two nuclear superpowers, the United States and Russia, which inherited the entire nuclear arsenal of the Soviet Union. Their relations have been growing more tense with every passing year.

There are many parallels between Moscow-Washington relations today and at the height of the Cold War. After the loss of the Soviet Union, its territories and international prestige, Russia is now a revisionist power, as it was in the 1950s and early 1960s, when it tried to change the world balance of power in the era of decolonization. Nor has ideology completely disappeared from the current stage of nuclear brinkmanship. The United States is still interested in the defense if not the advance of democracy. Russia is no longer communist, but it has replaced its communist expansionism with the self-proclaimed mission of defending conservative values and supporting authoritarian regimes. Cultural differences also persist between the nuclear powers, creating unlimited opportunities for misreading each other's intentions.[4]

But we also face a situation in which not only have old threats returned but new ones have appeared to make the situation even more unstable and dangerous. The unprecedented proliferation of nuclear weapons and missile technologies has dramatically increased the number of states that can launch a nuclear strike. Even extremely poor but determined regimes, such as the one that rules North Korea, can threaten a superpower with a nuclear war. Two rivals, India and Pakistan, both have nuclear capabilities, and Iran's acquisition of nuclear technology causes grave concern not only in the undeclared nuclear state of Israel but also in the non-nuclear regional hegemon Saudi Arabia. Cyberwarfare also makes the current situation more dangerous than that of the early 1960s, as it allows one power to seize control of another's nuclear arsenal without firing a shot.[5]